Vatsal Khandelwal

Contact Information

Department of Economics, University of Exeter
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Employment

Assistant Professor (Lecturer), Department of Economics
University of Exeter, 2024–present

Education

University of Oxford
Doctor of Philosophy (DPhil) in Economics (2017-2021)
Supervisors: Prof. Stefan Dercon, Prof. Alexander Teytelboym

University of Oxford
M.Sc., Economics for Development (2016-2017)
Awarded distinction. Luca D'Agliano Prize for Best Dissertation. George Webb Medley Prize (proxime accessit) for Best Overall Performance.

St. Xavier's College, Mumbai
B.A., Economics (2012-2015)
Awarded distinction. Batch Valedictorian (Arts) for highest CGPA.

Fellowships/ Visiting Appointments

University of Oxford
Academic Visitor, Department of Economics (2024-present)
Peter J. Braam Junior Research Fellow in Global Wellbeing, Merton College (2021–2024)

Stanford University
Visiting Scholar, King Center on Global Development (Summer 2023)

Harvard University
Visiting Fellow (Spring 2021)

Publications

"Learning in Networks with Idiosyncratic Agents." *Games and Economic Behaviour*, 2024. [Paper]

Working Papers

"Silent Networks: The Role of Inaccurate Beliefs in Reducing Useful Social Interactions" (with Ronak Jain). [Draft]
Awarded the Economics Job Market Best Paper Award, European Economic Association and UniCredit Foundation.
Coverage: VoxDev, Ideas of India Podcast at the Mercatus Centre.

"Spatial Inequality and Informality in Kenya's Firm Network" (with Verena Wiedemann, Peter Wankuru Chacha, and Benard Kipyegon Kirui). [Draft]
Revise and Resubmit, Economic Journal

"Personalized Teacher Attention and Student Achievement" (with Ronak Jain and Minahil Asim). [Draft]

Coverage: VoxDev

"Peer Effects in Social Networks: Evidence from an Entrepreneurship Experiment" (with Juni Singh). [Draft]

"Caring Until It Costs: Teacher Responses to Student Mental Well-being" (with Minahil Asim and Preetham Rodrigues). ***Revise and Resubmit, World Bank Economic Review***

Grants

BA/Leverhulme Small Research Grant (£9,954), 2026.

Joint PEDL and STEG Small Grant (£24,954), 2025. "Financial Frictions and Supply Chain Linkages in Kenya" with Verena Wiedemann, Peter Wankuru Chacha, and Benard Kirui.

CSAE Top up Research Grant (£6,440), 2022. "Silent Networks: The Role of Inaccurate Beliefs in Reducing Useful Social Interactions" with Ronak Jain.

JPAL Post Primary Education Grant ($20,548), 2020. "Great Expectations: Experimental Evidence from Schools in Pakistan" with Ronak Jain and Minahil Asim.

Research on Improving Systems of Education (RISE) Grant ($40,000), 2019. "Great Expectations: Experimental Evidence from Schools in Pakistan" with Ronak Jain and Minahil Asim.

Centre for the Study of African Economies Research Grant (£4,030), 2019. "Silent Networks: The Role of Inaccurate Beliefs in Reducing Useful Social Interactions" with Ronak Jain.

Scholarships and Prizes

Economics Job Market Best Paper Award, European Economic Association and UniCredit Foundation (2023)

Final Year Doctoral Bursary, Department of Economics, University of Oxford (2020)

Two Year Doctoral Bursary, Department of Economics, University of Oxford (2018)

Hicks Scholarship in Economics, Linacre College, University of Oxford (2017)

Luca D'Agliano Prize for Best Dissertation, MSc in Economics for Development, University of Oxford (2017). Awarded for "Social Networks, Risk Sharing and Circular Migration: Evidence from Rural India".

George Webb Medley Prize (proxime accessit), Best Overall Performance in the MSc in Economics for Development, University of Oxford (2017)

Queen Elizabeth House Departmental Scholarship for the MSc in Economics for Development (2016).

Dr. Edgar DaSilva Memorial Prize and Mr. Badi C Tyabjee, J.J & B.J Lalwani, and Billoo scholarship for highest aggregate in B.A. examinations, St. Xavier's College, Mumbai (2015)

Fredie A. Mehta Scholarship for highest marks in Economics in First and Second Year, St. Xavier's College, Mumbai (2014)

Certificate Of Merit by the Central Board of Secondary Education "*for reasons of outstanding academic performance and for being among the top 0.1% of successful candidates*" of the All India Senior School Certificate Examinations in Mathematics (2012).

Teaching

University of Exeter

Lecturer, Development Economics, undergraduate (2025–26)

Lecturer, Introduction to Econometrics, undergraduate (2024–25)

University of Oxford

Lecturer, MSc in Economics for Development

- Microeconomic Theory (2023–24): discrete and continuous games, hidden action, signalling, auctions

- Applications of Behavioural Economics to the Developing World (2022–23)

Graduate Teaching Assistant

- Microeconomics, MPhil in Economics (2020–21)

- Microeconomics, Game Theory & Quantitative Economics, Pembroke College (2018–20)

Refereeing

American Economic Review, Journal of the European Economic Association, Economic Development and Cultural Change, International Economic Review, Oxford Economic Papers

Other Activities

Organiser, Behind-the-Scenes Seminar Series (with Séverine Toussaert), an online series promoting transparency in the research process. (2025–)

Affiliated Researcher at Lab^2 — a metascience lab for experimentation in science. (2023-)

Managed CSAE's Coders' Corner – a repository of advice around coding.(2020-2021)

Software

Matlab, Stata, Mathematica, Gephi, LaTeX, Qualtrics